

Diablo Valley students in Pleasant Hill win big at entrepreneurship contest

Entrants from three Contra Costa community colleges showcase range of ideas at districtwide Business Pitch Competition



Anya Gupta, left, a student at Diablo Valley College's Pleasant Hill campus, shows the \$1,000 first prize she won at the Contra Costa Community College District's recent 4CD Business Pitch Competition held on the campus. Student entrepreneurs from across the district showcased ideas spanning wellness technology, food sustainability and student support services in the districtwide contest. (photo courtesy of Prashant Gupta)



By **CHARLEEN EARLEY** | Correspondent

PUBLISHED: January 2, 2026 at 3:10 PM PST

Student entrepreneurs from across the Contra Costa Community College District showcased ideas spanning wellness technology, food sustainability and student support services at the districtwide 4CD Business Pitch Competition, held recently at Diablo Valley College's Pleasant Hill campus.

The three-hour annual event brought together students from Contra Costa College, Diablo Valley College (DVC) and Los Medanos College. Ten finalist teams were selected from a competitive pool of 24 applicants to pitch their ventures before a panel of local leaders, entrepreneurs and industry experts.

At the conclusion of the competition, four student teams were awarded cash prizes based on originality, clarity of concept, presentation quality and demonstrated potential for real-world impact.

First place and a \$1,000 prize went to WellPulse, founded by DVC student Anya Gupta. Her platform was described as providing a 100% anonymous, QR code-based wellness survey that offers organizations real-time insights into mental health trends while protecting individual privacy.



Second place and \$500 was awarded to Leftoverly, founded by Zachary Lee, a dual-enrolled DVC student and Northgate High School junior. His platform is said to be designed to help restaurants reduce food waste by selling surplus meals at affordable prices.

Third place and \$250 went to Scholarise, founded by Floris Brussaard, which is described as helping community college students track scholarships, internships and coursework as they prepare to transfer to four-year universities.

Finally, the People's Choice Award, determined by an audience vote and accompanied by a \$50 prize, went to Garydian Angel, founded by Anzell Ross, a voice-activated wristband focused on calm, family-centered safety alerts.

"It's truly an honor to win first place in this competition," Gupta said. "I've been working on this project for more than two years, and to see it grow from a small idea into something making an impact on student mental health is incredible."

Gupta, a full-time DVC student from Walnut Creek, is completing an accelerated academic path and plans to transfer in fall 2026. She said the idea for WellPulse was inspired by the loss of a close friend to suicide and her growing involvement in mental health advocacy.

Through volunteer work at nonprofit groups and hospitals and leadership roles with Contra Costa County and regional transit agencies, Gupta said she became aware of a lack of real-time insight into how people are actually feeling. She said that experience pushed her to transform an early prototype into a fully functional product.

"What started here at Diablo Valley College has already reached the county level and even BART," Gupta said. "I really believe it can go global. This win reminds me that change can start with one person and one small idea — and I'm excited to keep building from here."

Lee, the second-place winner, is a first-year DVC student in the College Now dual-enrollment program and an 11th grader at Walnut Creek's Northgate High School. He lives in Concord and said Leftoverly was inspired by a short video he encountered online.

"I saw a man go into a Little Caesar's at closing time and ask if he could have the leftover food, and they gave it to him for free," Lee said. "It made me think about how many restaurants struggle with food waste and how many people don't realize how much good food goes unused."

Lee said participating in the competition was exciting and intimidating at the same time, particularly as a 16-year-old competing against older community college students.

"It taught me a lot about presenting and pitching in front of judges," he said. "This was my first time participating, and it was a great learning experience."

Leftoverly has two primary goals, Lee said: reducing food waste in local communities and improving food affordability by selling recovered food at reasonable prices for students and low-income families. While he plans to focus on his coursework for now, Lee said he may continue developing the business in the future.

Brussaard, a second-year DVC student who lives in Concord and is originally from Amsterdam, said Scholarise was born out of his own challenges navigating the transfer process.

"As a community college student, I was surprised by how complicated transferring to top-tier universities can be and how few centralized resources exist," he said. "That gap inspired the idea."

He said his team plans to package the prize money into a scholarship for underrepresented transfer students. He said he will transfer to Columbia University in the spring but remains committed to expanding Scholarise throughout California and supporting community college students.

Judges for the final competition included Kim Trupiano, the mayor of nearby Clayton; Ruby Grover, a business leader at Concord's Sunvalley Shopping Center; Nayab Siddiqui, the chief operating officer of ZAYNA Ventures; and Dan Siegel, a local entrepreneur. Entries were evaluated on writing quality, slide design, concept clarity and any demonstrated traction or early validation.

"This competition truly highlights the entrepreneurial spirit, creativity and determination of our students at DVC and our sister colleges," said Charlie Shi, dean of business, computer science, culinary arts and community education at DVC. "Their ideas reflect the potential of community college entrepreneurs to create generational wealth and shape the future of our regional economy."

Ryan Buckley, a DVC assistant professor of business administration and entrepreneurship, said each submission was reviewed by two members of a seven-person screening panel, with the highest-scoring teams advancing to the live pitch event.

"The ideas were incredibly diverse and reflected the varied backgrounds and interests of our students," Buckley said. "Seeing peers succeed helps students understand that entrepreneurship is attainable."

Reach Charleen Earley, a freelance writer and journalism professor at Diablo Valley college, at charleenbearley@gmail.com or 925-383-3072.

Around the Web

REVCONTENT



Why Your Sciatic Nerve Won't Heal (What Most Doctors Miss)

RejuvaCare
